



WHAT IS BEAUTY?

It sounds like an easy question to answer—a breathtaking sunset, a glimpse of a tiger, a glowing smile, or a bouquet of fresh flowers. But what makes these things beautiful? Shape, size, and color are some of the aspects of beautiful things that give pleasure. Though people usually find beauty in what they see with their eyes, it is also possible to describe a striking piece of music as beautiful. Mathematicians often speak of the beauty of numbers, while poets and writers can find great inspiration in nature's sounds and smells. These differing ideas of beauty are summed up by the expression "Beauty is in the eye of the beholder." This affirms that

everyone has their own idea of what is beautiful. Two people looking at pictures of fashion models may disagree over who is beautiful. In general, we absorb our ideas of beauty from the images we see all around us—in paintings, books and magazines, movies, and television—as well as what we learn from other people about what they find beautiful.

PERSPECTIVE AND TIME

Ideas of beauty (sometimes called aesthetics) change over time. During the 18th century's romantic movement, people found mountains ugly and threatening, but today, they are